

Purdue - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Low-end Power 4 team with a clearer quarterback/coordinator foundation than the 2025 results but too much turnover around it to project a reliable bowl push.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 78
Returning production	58% (No. 42) overall · Off. 61% (No. 38) · Def. 55% (No. 59)
Primer power rating	-2.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	3.4 wins · most likely 3-9
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better, but still a bottom-tier Power 4 profile
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: Purdue should lean on Ryan Browne and Josh Henson for offensive continuity while rebuilding the run game, receiving corps and line around them.

Bottom line: There is a credible improvement path from 2-10 because quarterback/play-caller continuity and a talented newcomer class raise the floor, but the amount of composition change and a top-20 schedule keep Purdue in the low-end Power 4 tier.

Beats expectations if: Browne turns continuity into a real efficiency jump, the transfer-heavy OL settles quickly, and Kane gets immediate improvement from a front/secondary rotation that has more options than certainty.

Disappoints if: the rebuilt line and skill groups remain replacement-level, the defense still loses too many successful downs and explosives, and unsettled LB/secondary/specialist roles fail to stabilize before Big Ten play.

Five things to remember

- Coaching:** Ryan Browne is the returning starting quarterback, and Josh Henson is the offensive play-caller.
- 2025 baseline:** Purdue was 2-10 in 2025 and ranked outside the top 100 in scoring offense, total offense, scoring defense and total defense.
- ? Key uncertainty:** The 2025 top three receiving-yard producers are all gone: WR Michael Jackson III (eligibility/graduation), WR Nitro Tuggle (transfer) and WR E.J. Horton (professional football).
- ? Defensive availability:** Charles Correa returns after 96 tackles, but 110-tackle Mani Powell is gone to professional football and the second major LB role remains open.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ projects only 3.4 wins against the No.18 schedule, with Notre Dame, Washington, Penn State, Iowa and Indiana all top-22 SP+ opponents.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	2-10 (0-9 Big Ten)	● Very poor
Scoring	18.8 PPG	● Very poor
Total offense	343.6 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	126.4 YPG · 4.0 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	6.43 YPA · 15 TD / 13 INT	● Poor
Third downs	38.4%	● Below average
Scoring defense	31.8 PPG allowed	● Poor
Total defense	423.5 YPG allowed	● Poor
Rush defense	181.8 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	241.7 YPG · 9.29 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Very poor

Purdue had no conventional statistical strength in 2025. The offense lacked efficiency and the defense gave up too much on both the ground and through the air, matching the 2-10 record.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-2.96 · No. 91	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.047 · No. 89	● Below average
Off. success rate	41.3% · No. 88	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.6% · No. 81	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	16.8% · No. 104	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-2.17 · No. 84	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.042 · No. 82	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	47.9% · No. 129	● Very poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.8% · No. 129	● Very poor
Havoc created	14.6% · No. 85	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: The advanced profile reveals no hidden strength: the offense was below average in EPA, success rate and adjusted rating, while the defense ranked No. 129 in both success-rate and explosive-play prevention.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Barry Odom - returning	● ↔ Program continuity helps, but on-field improvement still must follow
OC/TE / play-caller	Josh Henson - returning	● ↑ Same caller with QB Ryan Browne is the offense’s clearest continuity edge
DC/LB	◆ Kevin Kane - from Minnesota; prior Purdue familiarity	● ↔ Coordinator change with useful program familiarity

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Fame Ijeboi	Minnesota	● ↔ Doak Walker-watch newcomer has a plausible major role, but the room remains a competition rather than a proven upgrade.
◆ RB Jerrick Gibson	Texas	● ↔ Adds Power 4 talent to a rebuilt backfield after the leading rusher departed, with no lead-back role yet established.
◆ WR Xavier Townsend	Iowa State	● ↔ Needed major-role candidate in a receiver room replacing its top three 2025 yardage producers.
◆ OL Boaz Stanley	South Carolina	● ↔ One of five transfer linemen competing to form a new best five; useful experience but substantial projection risk remains.

Out	To	Loss
RB Devin Mockobee	Eligibility/graduation	● ↓ 2025 leading rusher (521 yards) leaves the rebuilt backfield.
WR Michael Jackson III	Eligibility/graduation	● ↓ 2025 receptions leader (63 catches, 570 yards) is a major receiving loss.
WR Nitro Tuggle	South Carolina	● ↓ 500-yard receiver transfers, compounding the loss of the top of the 2025 receiving order.
WR E.J. Horton	NFL (Indianapolis), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 receiver exits via a Colts UDFA path.

Offensive net: ● ↓ worse continuity with plausible talent replacement, but not enough proven role certainty to call the offense upgraded yet

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Curt Neal	Illinois	● ↔ Major front candidate in a unit replacing multiple 2025 contributors.
◆ DE Elo Modozie	Georgia	● ↔ Adds pass-rush competition and ceiling, but not a settled role.
◆ LB Jojo Hayden	Illinois	● ↔ Competes for the major role next to Charles Correa after Mani Powell's departure.
◆ DB Jaden Mangham	Michigan	● ↔ Experienced transfer option in the broad six-to-seven-player secondary competition.

Out	To	Loss
LB Mani Powell	NFL (Tennessee), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Co-led Purdue with 110 tackles; his loss creates the largest open linebacker role.
DE CJ Nunnally	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 44 tackles, 10.5 TFL and five sacks leave via a Falcons UDFA path.
S Tahj Ra-El	Eligibility/graduation	● ↓ Also co-led Purdue with 110 tackles and is a major secondary loss.
DB Myles Slusher	Eligibility/graduation	● ↓ 62-tackle secondary contributor departs, adding to the rebuild around Hines and Bradford.

Defensive net: ● ↔ roughly similar ceiling but lower certainty; transfer additions can improve athleticism, while major tackle/pass-rush/secondary production must be replaced

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Continuity-led offense built around Browne/Henson with a rebuilt supporting cast rather than an established schematic strength.	A returning starting quarterback, returning veteran WR Chauncey Magwood and multiple transfer options at RB/OL provide a plausible improvement path.	Line cohesion and proven receiving/rushing production after major turnover.
Defense	Kevin Kane-coordinated defense trying to pair pass rush and coverage while rotating a mix of returning anchors and transfers.	Charles Correa, CJ Madden, Ian Jeffries, Hudaury Hines and Smiley Bradford give each level at least one experienced reference point.	2025 success-rate/explosive prevention was poor and several major tackle/pass-rush/secondary roles are being replaced.
Special teams	Model-projected strength undergoing a full primary-specialist reset.	SP+ ranks Purdue special teams No.4 nationally.	The 2025 kicker and punter are both gone and final 2026 assignments are unresolved.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↑	High	Browne provides certainty and continuity, but the profile does not yet support an above-average Power 4 projection.
RB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	More talent options than a settled hierarchy.
WR	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	Top three 2025 receiving-yard producers are gone.
TE	● C+	● ↑	Medium	Burhenn’s return improves the room, but roles remain competitive.
OL	● C	● ↔	Low	Extensive transfer reconstruction with no settled final five.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	Returning anchors plus transfer depth, offset by major pass-rush loss.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Correa anchors a group with a large open role next to him.
Secondary	● C	● ↓	Low	Experienced returners exist, but the starting combination is heavily rebuilt and unsettled.
Special teams	● B	● ↓	Low	Strong model signal, but major specialist turnover lowers certainty.
Coaching	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	Offensive continuity plus a DC with prior Purdue familiarity, but performance still must improve.
Overall	● C	● ↑	Medium	A better-structured roster than the 2025 result suggests, but still a clear Power 4 weakness until the rebuilt units prove functional.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Ryan Browne	QB	● Low-end to functional Power 4 starter projection	-	Returning starter and offensive leader; continuity at quarterback is Purdue’s most important floor-raising asset.
Charles Correa	LB	● Established conference starter / defensive anchor	-	Returns after 96 tackles and becomes even more central after Mani Powell’s departure.
CJ Madden	DE	● Established defensive-front leader	-	Returning captain and one of the few stable reference points in a reshaped front.
Chauncey Magwood	WR	● Established conference starter / veteran leader	-	Clearest returning veteran in a receiver room that lost its top three 2025 yardage producers.
◆ Fame Ijeboi (TR: Minnesota)	RB	● High-upside major-role candidate	Doak Walker	Most recognized newcomer in an unsettled backfield with no settled lead back.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Hudauri Hines	DB	● Established secondary starter / anchor	-	Experienced returner around whom Purdue must rebuild a secondary that lost multiple major tacklers.
Smiley Bradford	DB	● Established secondary starter / anchor	-	Returning defensive back and one of the two most stable secondary pieces.
George Burhenn	TE	● Functional starter candidate / health return	-	Reported fully back after a 2025 season-ending injury and can add needed continuity at tight end.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Difficult for a rebuilding team, with limited relief beyond the FCS opener and a few swing games.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 18
Hardest stretch	Notre Dame -> at Illinois -> Minnesota -> Washington
Swing games	Wake Forest, Maryland, Wisconsin, Minnesota
Advantage	Indiana State opens the season at home and the lone bye arrives before the late five-game run.
Expected	3.4 wins · most likely 3-9
Floor / ceiling	1-11 / 6-6

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A 2-10 prior record and No.78 SP+ rank should keep expectations modest, creating possible underdog value only if the Browne/Henson continuity produces an early efficiency jump.
Back them when	As a meaningful underdog against opponents that cannot stress the rebuilt secondary vertically, especially if the OL and RB hierarchy stabilize and Purdue can lean on its projected special-teams edge.
Fade/pass when	When Purdue is asked to win through receiver depth, protect against strong pass rushes, or cover explosive offenses before the secondary and Kane rotation prove stable.
Key monitor	final offensive-line five, RB hierarchy, second linebacker role, secondary starters, kicker/punter winners, early offensive efficiency under Browne/Henson
Week 1 baseline	vs. Indiana State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Purdue –35.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Purdue's clearest reason for improvement is continuity where it matters most: QB Ryan Browne and OC Josh Henson return together. Nearly everything around them is being rebuilt, especially RB, WR and OL, so better structure does not yet equal a proven offense.

DC Kevin Kane inherits returning anchors but major LB/pass-rush/secondary turnover, and the specialist jobs also reset. Against SOS No. 18, **3.4 wins and 3-9** remains the baseline even with a credible path above last year's 2-10.

About this primer

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